

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Lent 5

The Only Thing More Powerful Than Hate is Love

Persevering

22 March 2026



Dame Laura Knight, R.A., R.W.S - At the Edge of the Cliff, 1917

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
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The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Hymn Improvisation

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

ATTENDE DOMINE (arr. C. Bull)

Autobahn-Toccata (after Bach and Kraftwerk)

LONESOME VALLEY (arr. C. Bull)

Invention dans le style ancien (Henriette Renié)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Michael Lehman

Words of Gathering

Rev. Lehman & Megan Mascena

We gather now,
harvesters of an all-pervasive love,
unexpected benefactors of the deed
to this great and glorious cosmic inheritance.

We, the walking, waking stars, ablaze with wonder,
imagination, and hope,
gather to remember three words:
kinship with all that is;
love that can only be paid forward;
grace sacred mantra of the humble.

Creation,
the great and glorious sacrifice of abundance, asks in return—
only – that we shed our entitled egos
and drop to our knees,
uttering a single, simple prayer
that changes everything:
“Thank you.” [adapt/bruces/lvf]

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Lenten Hymn of Gathering** *God, Composer and Conductor*

REGENT SQUARE

God, composer and conductor of earth's matchless symphony,
Makes from silence glorious music, from discordance, harmony;
Brings forth joy from deepest sorrow, ecstasy from agony.

God, the architect and artist of earth's colors, textures, forms,
Gives new wonder to our vision, light in even darkest storms,
Teaches that with understanding, faith redeems and love reforms.

God of science, healer, teacher, pushes out the boundaries
Of capacity and knowledge, challenges and gently frees
From the limits that restrain us, offers opportunities.

God, creative spirit in us, inspiration, force sublime,
Leading us to new endeavor, you, our living paradigm,
May we know your constant presence now, and to the end of time.
-lyrics by Jocelyn Marshall

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Lehman

Holiness, Mystery, Namelessness,
what power is it that charms mere dust into who we are?
What gives us purpose and meaning, O God,
and turns us loose to work our will upon this world?

*We live with such a multitude of images –
so many ways in which we seek and find the answers –
so many facets of a sacred likeness.*

And yet, Holy One, to see the whole of it
would be to lose the senses
with which we navigate this world –
to die in the presence of this holiness.

*The whole of its likeness is beyond us,
its beauty too profound.*

Mysterious One, because we cannot call such wonder
to come and stand before us,
because we cannot examine it nor call it ours,
may we seek this day, to find it in the eyes of those we meet,
helping us piece together the whole of its splendor
from the souls that surround us.

*We pray this in the name of the Christ,
whose gracious life helps us discern
the path of love in this world.
Amen and Amen.*

***Introit**

"Song of Brigid"

LAURA ASH

Cathedral Choir, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Soloist*, Dr. Fahad Siadat, *Assistant Conductor*

***The Lord's Prayer for Lent**

Megan Mascena

*Loving Presence, luminous in all creation,
hallowed be your name.
Thy kin-dom come.
May we reflect on earth
the yielding perfection of the heavens.*

*Help us to receive an illumed measure from the earth this day.
Forgive us when we trespass against others,
human and other than human,
as we forgive others who trespass against us.
Keep us on the path of wisdom
when we are tempted to take the selfish path.
May it be your rule we follow,
your power we exercise,
and your radiance that allures.*

*May this be the truth that guides our lives,
the ground from which our future will grow,
until we meet again.* [BSanguin/dddc]
Amen and Amen!

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Lehman

We come to this moment, aware that peace in our world is so elusive.
Our hearts are filled with prayers for our siblings who are living in war zones
across our world - places where it feels as if peace will never come.

Yet, ever just beyond our reach,
the sacred calls us to new understandings of ourselves
and to new ways of embracing the world.
Ever in pursuit of us,
it challenges us to name each place we find,
each corner in which we think ourselves alone, 'Holy.'
Ever within us,
it fills us to overflowing with a great love
so that,
ever amongst us,
it might be made known in this challenging world.

As we have the privilege of sharing this ancient greeting,
we invite you to bow to one another as you recognize
the Divine light that dwells within all people, everywhere.

This morning, may the Peace and Love of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Reading from Our Religious Tradition
from the Gospel of Luke

Megan Mascena

This is the Gospel of Love and Grace,
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Sometimes, God of life, we do things that make it hard
for the best of life to live among us.
We crush it with our lack of hope;
we fail to affirm it when we see it begin to grow in its fragility;
we destroy it with exploitation and injustice;
we can't image it coming from some people,
or we fail to give it support,
because our own life feels so untethered
and seeing the goodness flowing in others,
brings a sadness without a known origin.
Forgive us when we make it hard for life to live, O God.

Silence

But this morning we affirm, O God, that because of the Christ,
life does rise from the depths of our failures, our pain, and our grief.
We give thanks to you, God, that this life is never defeated but that you are
always and forever calling us to move into the future with you.
In this time, let us look carefully at you, let us look carefully at each other,

and let us see all the resources and gifts
which contribute to this incredible life growing among us.

And then, O God, help us see how opening our hands and our hearts
will allow your life to grow within us, and among us.

*Together, as one people, we pray this in gratitude
for the One who showed us the way to live.
Amen and Amen.*

Meditation Anthem

“O Come, Emmanuel”

arr. THE CLARK SISTERS,
TEXT, CHRISTIN BYRDSONG

Christin Byrdson, Dr. Ianthe Marini, and Frank Hobbs, *Trio*, Dr. Christoph Bull, *Piano*

“O come, O come Emmanuel, bring mercy where the walls divide. Release the weary from their chains. Let truth and justice now abide. Rejoice, rejoice Emmanuel shall make the wounded nations well. O come, O come Emmanuel heal every wound in sacred land. Let those who wander find their home, and walk together hand in hand. Rejoice, rejoice Emmanuel shall make the wounded nations well.”

Sermon

Persevering

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

The Eucharist and Blessings

Rev. Lehman & Rev. Fregin

Words of Invitation and Remembrance

With our eyes wide open, we come to this table
knowing the realities of our chaotic world.

We now live in a time and place
where anger is being honed to a painful edge,
where fear far too often reigns,
and shards of broken trust are used as weapons,
rending into tatters the relationships once built on trust.

In this too-fragile world,
we look for ways to strengthen love
in every possible way,
as we strive to live in ways that lift each other's souls,
and build, for every single human being,
a place that they might know
the beauty of being celebrated for who they are.

*At this table we break bread, share stories, build new and
hope-filled memories as we let go of the hurts and heartaches
of other times and other tables.*

At this table we fill ourselves up with the things of love
that we might live strong and confident
in the places we hold in this world.

As those who hold a vision of a love-filled world,
we break this bread as Jesus did,
and we eat together knowing it is the bread of new life.

We also pour and share a cup as Jesus did,
because we want others to come and drink
this cup of hope along with us.

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Invitation to Generosity

Megan Mascena

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

"Hope Lingers On" LISSA SCHNECKENBURGER, arr. ANDREA RAMSEY
Cathedral Choir, Dr. Fahad Siadat, *Assistant Conductor*

***Lenten Doxology**

Praise God from whom all blessings flow.
Praise God, all creatures here below.
Praise God above ye heavenly hosts.
Creator, Christ, and Holy Ghost.

***Offering Prayer**

Megan Mascena

Gracious and Loving God,
you who are always and forever with us,
remind us once again, that we are your beloved.

On this day, we give thanks that you created us with
intelligence, common sense,
and the ability to have a deep faith.
We give thanks for those who have gone before us –
for their experience, wisdom, and creativity.
We give thanks for the faith and hope and love that surround us.
And we give thanks most of all, O God, for one another.

Use these gifts that we share today,
to help us bring all our love to the world
as we co-create our future with you.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen.

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Fregin

May the Mystery we call God
keep alive in each one of us
the search for Love that is real;
Love that helps us live more joyful lives
Love that gives us a fuller
meaning to life and the events of life.

*Bring us, O God, the goodness that flows
from the heart of Love
and may we be expanded in heart and soul*

*by that Love.
This is our prayer.
Amen! May it be so!*

Choral Response

"We Walk In Love"
Cathedral Choir, Dr. Fahad Siadat, *Assistant Conductor*

DEANNA WITOWSKI

***Hymn for the Journey**

When Love is Found

O WALY WALY

When love is found and hope comes home,
Sing and be glad we all are one.
When love explodes and fills the sky,
Praise God, and share our Maker's joy.

When love has flowered in trust and care,
Build both each, that love may dare
To reach beyond earth's warmth and light,
To serve and strive for truth and right.

Praise God for love, praise God for life,
In age and youth, in calm or strife.
Lift up your hearts! Let love be fed
Through death and life in broken bread.

-lyrics by Brian Wren/lf

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*
Postlude in F minor (Luise Adolpha Le Beau)